

ASHENFALL — Progression Design

Companion document to DESIGN.md (v0.7) · Solo · Soulslike difficulty
Prepared 2026-09-26

1. Design intent

Progression in *Ashenfall* is **gated by discovery and gear, never by grind walls**. Three rules govern it:

1. **You can always move the story forward.** If you're stuck, there is always a landmark you haven't found or a boss you haven't beaten. Grinding is *available* and *rewarded*, but never *required* to advance.
2. **Gear is a check, not a treadmill.** Each tier asks "do you have the right gear *and* the right skills?" — not "have you spent 20 more hours?"
3. **Every tier ends with a boss that proves you learned something.** If a boss is beating you, the answer is a mechanic, a movement option, or a gear tier — not more levels.

Total expected playtime: ~80–100 hours (Act I $\approx$ 45 hours).

2. The critical path at a glance

Tier	Chapter	Est.	Landmark you must find	Boss	Gear tier at exit	Skill target
0	Ch 0–1 "The Cold Shore"	6h	The Drowned Chapel	— (mini- bosses)	Iron → Diamond	Combat 15, Smithing 10
1	Ch 2 "Cold Star"	5h	The Cold Tower	Night Lich	Diamond + boss weapon	Combat 20, Smithing 15
2	Ch 3 "The Burning Arena"	9h	The Burning Arena	Ignis , Nether Gauntlet	Netherite → Witherite	Combat 30, Smithing 25
3	Ch 4 "Skyfall"	9h	The Sunken Spire	Slider → Valkyrie Queen → Sun Spirit	Witherite → Aether	Combat 35, Smithing 30
4	Ch 5 "The Hollow Court"	16h	The Hollow Gate, The Labyrinth	Naga → Lich → Hydra → Ur-Ghast	Aether → Hollow Court	Combat 45, Smithing 40
5	Ch 6 "The Deep Answers"	11h	The Otherside Rift	Cave champions + Obsidilith prep	Hollow Court → deep gear	Combat 50, Smithing 45
6	Ch 7 "The End of Pilgrims"	11h	The Emperor's Last City	Obsidilith → Ender Golem → The Harbinger	End tier	Combat 55, Smithing 50

7	Ch 8 "Ashenfall"	16h	The Cathedral of Ash (only via the 12 Annals)	Ancient Remnant → Leviathan → Scylla → Maledictus	Ashen	Combat 60+, Smithing 55
---	---------------------	-----	--	--	-------	----------------------------

Side content (optional, ~20h): Lore Codex (24 entries), The Lich's Bargain, 12 Hollow Challenges, Dimensional Dungeons runs, Bestiary, all nine nation standing lines, the Museum of the Pilgrim.

3. Tier-by-tier detail

Tier 0 — Pilgrim's Road (Chapters 0–1, ~6h)

Entry: nothing. You wake on a shore with no memory and a cold Ember.

What you do:

- Gather wood, stone, iron. **FallingTree + Woodcutting** makes this fast and starts the skill curve.
- Find the first village (Norman Remnant) — your first contact with a nation.
- Choose a **class token** (Vanguard / Reaver / Ranger / Ember-Warden).
- Explore the Heartland: Delver's Ends (reworked dungeons), taverns, Structory ruins.
- Find **The Drowned Chapel** — your first landmark.

Gear target: full iron, then diamond if you can find it. **Weapon:** vanilla or Simply Swords entry tier.

Skill target: Combat 15 · Mining 10 · Woodcutting 10 · Smithing 10.

Unlocks: Ember Flask (5 charges) · class choice · first Waystone

(bonfire) · Nature's Compass · Sophisticated Backpack · Explorer's Compass at chapter end.

Exit criteria: Night Lich tower located (soul stars + Inuit rumours) and diamond-tier gear in hand.

Tier 1 — Cold Star (Chapter 2, ~5h)

Entry: diamond-ish gear, 5 flask charges, Waystone network started.

What you do:

- Travel north into the Inuit North. Rivers from Dynamic Waters are your safest route — and the best ambush spots.
- Follow soul stars to **The Cold Tower** (BOMD Night Lich).
- Fight the **Night Lich**: projectile volleys, teleports, cover pillars. Learn to use cover and roll timing.

Gear target: diamond + the Tier-1 boss weapon.

Skill target: Combat 20 · Smithing 15.

Unlocks: **Seal Shard #1** · +1 flask charge · first music disc · the nations *notice* you (standing events begin) · The Byzantine Choir sends an Archivist.

Exit criteria: Ignis path opened — Nether access and ashes farming understood.

Tier 2 — The Burning Arena (Chapter 3, ~9h)

Entry: Seal Shard #1, boss weapon, 6 flask charges.

What you do:

- Enter the Nether (now scaled hard). Farm **Ignited Revenants** for **Ashes of the Arena**.

- Summon and fight **Ignis** in the Burning Arena: fire phases, shield-break with axe crits. This is the pack's first "you must read the fight" boss.
- Side: **Nether Gauntlet** structure.
- Build the **Mechanical Fusion Anvil** — the pack's central crafting station.

Gear target: netherite → **Witherite** tier (the anvil unlocks the whole line).

Skill target: Combat 30 · Smithing 25 · Mining 30.

Unlocks: Mechanical Fusion Anvil · Witherite gear · +1 flask charge · backpack tank upgrade · Nether waystones.

Exit criteria: Aether portal catalyst located (Cartographer's Map from a Norman vault).

Tier 3 — Skyfall (Chapter 4, ~9h)

Entry: Witherite gear, Mechanical Fusion Anvil, 7 flask charges.

What you do:

- Find **The Sunken Spire** and build the Aether portal.
- Bronze dungeons → **Slider** → **Valkyrie Queen** → **Sun Spirit**.
- First real **mounted combat**: SWEM horses + spear charge. Breed for speed.
- Gravitite gear; Moas for traversal.

Gear target: Aether tier (Zanite → Gravitite).

Skill target: Combat 35 · Smithing 30 · Archery 20.

Unlocks: Gravitite · Moa mount · Aether artifacts · +1 flask charge · nation horse lines begin · **first spell book and Inscription Table — the magic track opens here.**

Exit criteria: Twilight portal materials + Hollow Gate located (Choir

lore).

Tier 4 — The Hollow Court (Chapter 5, ~16h) — *the centerpiece*

Entry: Aether gear, 8 flask charges.

What you do:

- Build the Twilight portal. Enter **the Hollow Court** — the Empire's lost province, frozen mid-collapse.
- Magic-map progression: **Naga** → **Lich** → **Hydra** → **Ur-Ghast**, each unlocking the next.
- **The Labyrinth** puzzle (Twilight's native maze + a custom "thread" item).
- Side: **The Lich's Bargain** (The Graveyard's full quest chain) — recommended here.
- Explore all nine nations' capitals; build standing; hear each nation's account of the fall.

Gear target: Hollow Court tier (Ironwood → Steeleaf → Knightmetal).

Skill target: Combat 45 · Smithing 40 · Archery 30.

Unlocks: Knightmetal · +2 flask charges · waystone network expansion · nation gear lines at +30 standing · first nation ultimates at +80.

Exit criteria: Otherside Rift located.

Tier 5 — The Deep Answers (Chapter 6, ~11h)

Entry: Knightmetal gear, 10 flask charges.

What you do:

- Explore the five **Alex's Caves** cave biomes (skippable chapter if the port misbehaves).

- Enter **the Otherside** via the Rift.
- Cave champions, mini-bosses (Mini-boss Boss Bars gives free boss bars here).
- Prepare for the End.

Gear target: deep gear — Darkness Armor, Dreadbow/Raygun, plus the Alex's Caves material line.

Skill target: Combat 50 · Smithing 45.

Unlocks: Darkness Armor · Dreadbow/Raygun · +1 flask charge · backpack mob catcher → **Bestiary quest**.

Exit criteria: End access + Obsidilith located.

Tier 6 — The End of Pilgrims (Chapter 7, ~11h)

Entry: deep gear, 11 flask charges.

What you do:

- The End, reworked: **The Emperor's Last City** (YUNG's Better End Island).
- **Obsidilith** → **Ender Golem** → **The Harbinger**.
- Collect the remaining Seal Shards from nation champions.
- Begin assembling **the 12 Annals**.

Gear target: End tier.

Skill target: Combat 55 · Smithing 50.

Unlocks: **Gauntlet Key** · End gear · waystone network complete · final nation ultimates.

Exit criteria: all 12 Annals collected → **Cathedral of Ash location revealed**.

Tier 7 — Ashenfall (Chapter 8, ~16h)

Entry: End gear, Gauntlet Key, all 12 Annals, full flask.

What you do:

- The Gauntlet: **Ancient Remnant** → **The Leviathan** → **Scylla** → **Maledictus**.
- The 12 **Hollow Challenges** (optional, needed for the hidden ending).
- The final revelation and the **ending choice**.

Gear target: **Ashen** tier — forged at the custom Ashen Anvil from the last boss's material.

Skill target: Combat 60+ · Smithing 55.

Unlocks: the Ashenfall weapon · epilogue · NG+ flag.

4. Skill leveling curve

Project MMO skills gate recipes and grant attributes. Targets are *soft* — you'll naturally exceed them.

Skill	T0	T1	T2	T3	T4	T5	T6	T7
Combat	15	20	30	35	45	50	55	60+
Smithing	10	15	25	30	40	45	50	55
Mining	10	20	30	35	40	45	50	60
Woodcutting	10	20	30	30	35	40	45	50
Archery	5	10	15	20	30	35	40	45
Alchemy	5	10	15	20	30	35	40	45
Farming	5	10	15	20	25	30	35	40
Fishing	5	10	15	20	25	30	35	40

Magic (<i>Hexer only; runs in parallel — see §4A</i>)	—	—	—	opens	15	30	45	60
--	---	---	---	-------	----	----	----	----

Design note: FallingTree's logs-per-cut is gated by Woodcutting, so the two biggest early skills (Woodcutting and Mining) advance fastest — which is exactly where a new player spends their time.

4A. The magic track (Hexer / any spell-imbued build)

Magic runs **in parallel** to the gear ladder — you are never forced onto it, but it is a complete second character progression with its own chain, and it is the only way to fill an imbued-spell slot.

Stage	What you need	Where it comes from
1. Arcane Essence	Kill spellcasters (Pyromancers, Cryomancers, Priests, Apothecarists, Necromancers, Archevokers)	Overworld/Nether magical encounters
2. Scroll Forge	Paper + a school Focus + Ink of a chosen rarity	First magical structure; arcane essence
3. Spell Book	A craftable book tier (iron → diamond → netherite; 6 → 10 → 12 slots)	Vanilla-ish crafting, upgraded with nether resources
4. Inscription Table	Inscribe scrolls into the book; extract them freely without losing levels	Early — this is your loadout screen
5. School armour	Ten school sets; each adds max mana and boosts one school's spell power	Magical structures, runestones, Arcane Anvil upgrades

6. Arcane Anvil	Upgrade scrolls (level 1–10, Common → Legendary), upgrade armour, imbue a weapon with a spell	The magic endgame station
7. Eldritch	An Eldritch Manuscript , consumed on use	Late-game structure chests or Eldritch-themed enemies only — no compass finds this
8. The magic bosses	Dead King (Catacombs) → Keeper (Lost Citadel) → Fire Boss (Echo of Tyros)	Each drops unique gear; the Dead King drops the Necronomicon

You don't have to cast a spell to benefit from this track. The **Arcane Anvil imbues weapons**, so a pure melee build can carry one spell on its signature weapon — that's the cheapest, most interesting build diversity in the pack, and it's why the magic layer is worth building even if you never open a spell book yourself.

Balance notes:

- Spells cost **mana**, have **cast times** and **cooldowns** — so a Hexer trades the melee classes' uptime for range, AoE and utility. Cast times mean you must commit to a position, which is a soulslike constraint, not a limitation.
 - **Wizard NPCs sell materials** (essence, ink, focuses, runestones) but their **scroll trades are stripped** — you cannot buy power, only ingredients.
 - **The Witchbane Crusaders start hostile to you at –40** and their patrols will hunt a spellcaster. That is a real cost of the class, and the reason the Choir's protection matters.
 - Imbued weapons mean a melee build can carry one spell (e.g. Fang Ward on a katana) — the cheapest, most interesting build diversity in the pack.
-
-

5. Ember Flask progression

Milestone	Charges	Effect
Chapter 0 reward	5	Base
Night Lich	6	
Ignis	7	
Valkyrie Queen	8	
Hydra	9	
The Otherside	10	
The Harbinger	11	Max charges
Spice Kingdoms standing (+50)	—	Flask efficiency: each charge heals more
Hollow Challenges (all 12)	—	Instant-flask: drinking is faster

Refills only at Waystones, boss arenas, and taverns/camps. **Dying never refills.**

6. Waystone & rest-point progression

Chapter	Unlocked	Notes
0	First Waystone (Heartland)	Craftable, placeable
1	Inuit North network	
2	Nether waystones	
3	Aether waystones	
4	Hollow Court + full Overworld network	Fast Travel Waypoints (world-map UI) enabled

5	Otherside	
6	End + network complete	
7	—	Rest points everywhere; travel stops being a constraint

7. Boss preparation checklist

Generic prep that applies to every boss — this is the "loadout screen" the pack gives you without a menu:

- ☐ **Flask full** (refill at the nearest rest point)
- ☐ **Embers recovered** (never enter a boss arena carrying unrecovered Embers)
- ☐ **No Withering** (–HP debuff from unrecovered deaths)
- ☐ **Right tier gear** (check the tier table — being one tier under is the most common cause of a wipe)
- ☐ **Right consumables** (cooked meals from Farmer's Delight for saturation; potions for the specific fight)
- ☐ **Right weapon** (axe for shield-breaks, spear for mobility/damage-at-speed, bow for flying phases)
- ☐ **Movement options ready** (blocks for vaulting, a roll charged, parkour stamina full)
- ☐ **Backpack sorted** (tool swapper set, spare weapons)

Fight-specific notes:

Boss	What to bring	What to learn
Night Lich	Bow, cover blocks	Use pillars; punish teleport recovery
Ignis	Axe (shield-break), fire resistance	Phase timing; don't chase

Netherite Monstrosity	Range, mobility	Lava phase positioning
Slider	Knockback resistance	Arena hazards
Valkyrie Queen	Bow, vertical mobility	Air phase
Sun Spirit	Range, cover	Beam patterns
Naga	Bow, arena circling	Segment order
Lich	Shield, adds clear	Multi-phase discipline
Hydra	High DPS, mobility	Head regrowth windows
Ur-Ghast	Bow, vertical movement	Tear dodging
Obsidilith	Mobility, range	Laser patterns
Ender Golem	Shield, dodge	Shockwave timing
The Harbinger	Max DPS, mobility	Flying phase
Ancient Remnant	Best melee gear, stamina	Hardest melee check
The Leviathan	Riptide trident / water mobility	Water combat
Scylla	Range, storm positioning	Arena phases
Maledictus	Everything	All mechanics combined
Dead King (Catacombs)	Spell book, mana gear, school armour	Summon phases; the Necronomicon is the prize
The Keeper (Lost Citadel)	Imbued weapon, cooldown gear	Arena control; punishes standing still
The Fire Boss (Echo of Tyros)	Fire resistance, range	Beam patterns, add waves

8. Collection checklists

Collection	Size	Reward
Lore Codex (structure entries)	24	Set completions grant permanent upgrades + landmark reveals
The Pilgrim's Journal	24 pages	Required for the hidden ending
The Empire's Annals	12 texts	Required to find the Cathedral of Ash (the ending gate)
Artifacts (Artifacts mod)	~20	Attribute bonuses per set
Relics (Enigmatic Legacy+)	~12	Build-defining
Unique weapons (Simply Swords)	~8	—
Boss music discs	~10	Lore entries
Bestiary (backpack mob catcher)	~30 mobs	Ember-Warden class bonuses
Hearts / permanent upgrades	~10	+max health
Nation ultimates	9 (one per nation at +100)	—
Ember Runes	9 (one hidden behind a secret in each nation capital)	Assemble all nine → the Hidden Cathedral opens (Ashen tier material + a fourth ending)

9. Side content & grinding loops

Loop	Where	Rewards
Delver's End farming	Reworked dungeons	Skill XP, loot, Codex pages
Dimensional Dungeons runs	Portal anywhere	Renewable loot, skill books, XP bottles
Hollow Challenges	12 arenas	Cosmetics, permanent upgrades, hidden-ending requirement
The Lich's Bargain	Graveyard structures	Bone staff, Ghouling companion, rare artifacts
Nation standing lines	Nine capitals	Gear lines, ultimates, quests
Horse breeding	SWEM stables	Faster mounts → higher spear charge damage
Mob farms	Mob Grinding Utils	Materials, XP bottles, mob drops
Village defence	Guard Villagers raids	Standing, loot, Hero of the Village
River/ocean sailing	Dynamic Waters + boats	Remote landmarks, Currents of Trade harbours
Champion hunting	Mob Champions anywhere	Rank loot that can't be crafted or bought — the reason to patrol old regions
Threat-tier pushes	Raise a region's Ashenfall Threat tier	Rarer loot, more champions, harder scaling — the long-term loop
Magical structure raids	Catacombs / Lost Citadel / Echo of Tyros	Runestones, arcane essence, school armour, the Eldritch Manuscript

10. Difficulty bands (distance from origin)

Band	Distance	Mob scaling	Structure density	Intended gear
Heartland	0–1,500	×1.0	High (starter dungeons, villages)	Iron–Diamond
The Reaches	1,500–6,000	×1.3–1.8	High (all nation capitals, WDA-class ruins)	Diamond–Witherite
The Frontier	6,000–20,000	×2.0–3.0	Medium (rare, remote)	Aether–End
The Ashen Wastes	20,000+	×3.5+	Low	Endgame only

The Frontier and Wastes are where the infinite world earns its keep: there is always somewhere further, always worse, and occasionally something worth the trip.

On top of the bands sits The Ashenfall Threat — seven selectable tiers per region, each raised by clearing that region's bosses at the current tier. Tier VII Heartland is *harder* than Tier I Frontier, so the tiers let you re-play a region you already cleared at a difficulty that still means something. Raising a tier is itself the reward loop: more champions, rarer loot, harder scaling.

11. "I'm stuck" guide

Symptom	Likely cause	Fix
---------	--------------	-----

Boss one-shots me	One tier undergeared	Farm the previous tier's material line; check skill levels
I can't find the next landmark	Compass not crafted / map not found	Explorer's Compass (craft), Cartographer's Maps in taverns, ask a nation's villagers for rumours
I keep dying on the way to a boss	Route too dangerous	Use river valleys; pregen the route with Chunky; rest at waystones; don't travel carrying Embers
I've lost my Embers	Died twice before recovering	Grind a dungeon for XP bottles; nothing is permanently lost except those Embers
Gear feels weak	Reforged modifiers / Attribute Modify tuning	Reroll modifiers at an anvil with a Reforged hammer (villagers sell these)
FPS dropping	Entity/structure density	Apply the cut order in DESIGN.md §6.11; switch to the <code>compat</code> profile

12. New Game+ ("New Pilgrimage")

The epilogue plants the hook: a **New Pilgrimage** flag is set at the ending. Design intent (implement later):

- Carry over skills, class, and collection progress
 - Mob scaling +1 band from the start
 - Exclusive NG+ gear line and a fourth, hidden ending
 - The Ashenfall weapon carries over as the starting weapon
-

Boss, landmark, and chapter details are specified in DESIGN.md §5.2, §5.5, §9 and §10. Story beats are in LORE.md.